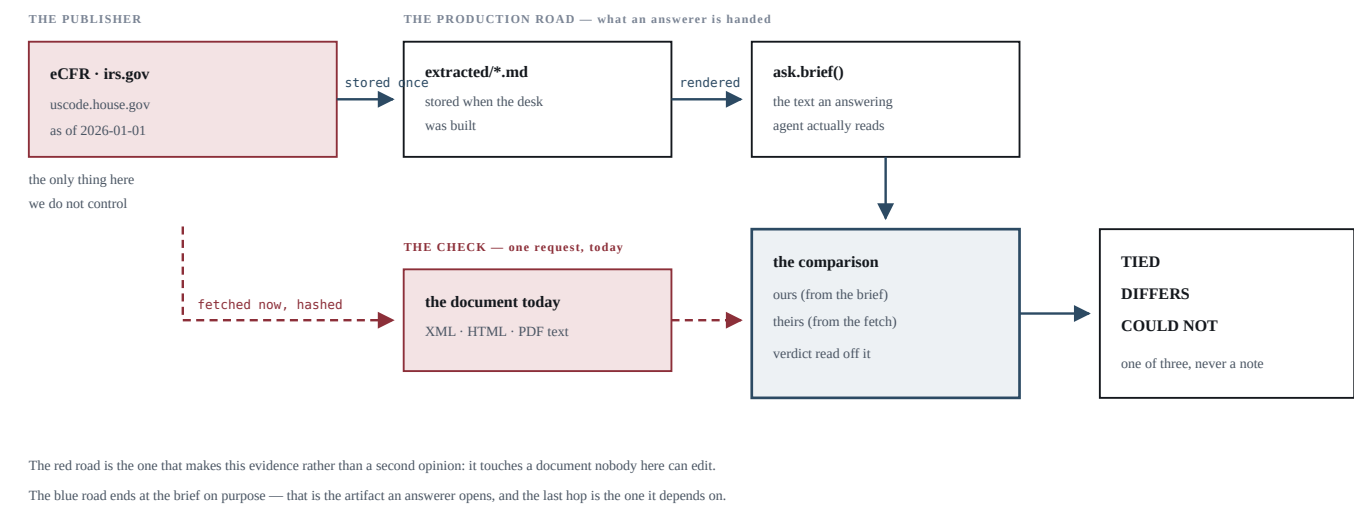


# personal-or-business

Every passage this desk hands to an answering agent, put back to the publisher that wrote it. **The question is not whether our tests pass.** It is whether the authority we serve is what the authority actually says — which no test in this repository can answer, because they all read the same stored files.



The same passage, two roads. They meet at the comparison, and the verdict is read off that block rather than written ahead of it.

## The roster

|         |           |          |                      |
|---------|-----------|----------|----------------------|
| 0       | 0         | 34 of 34 | 3                    |
| DIFFERS | COULD NOT | TIED     | SOURCES FETCHED LIVE |

Of the **34** that tied, **33** matched the publisher's characters exactly and **1** matched only once whitespace was ignored — which is declared, and explained under what this does not prove.

## The sample of one, worked end to end

The longest passage on this desk, because a long one has the most places to be wrong.

### 1 · THE FIGURE — AND WHERE A READER SEES IT

Not a row of a database: the paragraph of authority the desk hands an answering agent under the citation IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Qualifying for a Deduction" – the six ways to qualify. It is read out of ask.brief(), which is the text that agent opens, and it is 642 characters long.

To qualify to deduct expenses for business use of your home, you must use part of your home: Exclusively and regularly as your principal place of business (see Principal Place of Business , later); Exclusively and regularly as a place where you meet or deal with patients, clients, or customers in the normal course of your trade or business; In the case of a separate structure that is not attached to your home, in connection with your trade or business; On a regular basis for certain storage use (see Storage of inventory or product samples , later); For rental use (see Pub. 527); or As a daycare facility (see Daycare Facility , later).

2 · THE CALL — COPY-PASTABLE, WITH THE REAL VALUES IN IT

```
curl -sS --compressed "https://www.irs.gov/publications/p587"
```

Fetched 2026-09-06 02:22:36Z · 439,347 bytes · SHA-256  
83633a47882eb4da885fc23b23b9a2285c9a27be72dbfb3bba77d0d22a054569

3 · THE DERIVATION — WHAT HAPPENS BETWEEN THE TWO

The response is turned into plain text: an XML or HTML document has its inline tags closed up and its block tags turned into a space, a PDF is read page by page. Both sides are then folded the same way — Unicode normalised, and the typographic quotes and dashes publishers vary between renderings mapped to their plain forms. **Nothing else is changed.** The stored text either occurs in the publisher's document or it does not.

4 · THE INDEPENDENT SOURCE — CAPTURED, NOT SUMMARISED

The publisher's own words around the match, quoted verbatim out of the bytes whose hash is printed above. **A reader re-fetches that URL, recomputes the hash, and gets the same digits** — which is a check a photograph cannot offer.

... and Figure A to decide if you can deduct expenses for the business use of your home. To qualify to deduct expenses for business use of your home, you must use part of your home: Exclusively and regularly as your principal place of business (see Principal Place of Business, later); Exclusively and regularly as a place where you meet or deal with patients, clients, or customers in the normal course of yo...

5 · THE COMPARISON

|        |                                                               |
|--------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| ours   | (ask.brief → IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Qualifying for a Deductio) |
|        | 642 characters                                                |
| theirs | (https://www.irs.gov/publications/p587)                       |
|        | 642 of them found, verbatim, in the document fetched above    |
| diff   | none                                                          |

**TIED — exact once whitespace is ignored, which is declared below**

| VERDICT | CITATION                                                              | CHARS | HOW / WHY |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|-----------|
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.162-1(a) – an expense exceeding the income of the business   | 221   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.162-1(a) – the items business expenses include               | 547   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.162-1(a) – what a business expense is                        | 286   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.162-1(b)(2) – items not deductible                           | 90    | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(a) – the general rule                                  | 167   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b) – how the examples are introduced                   | 80    | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(1) – life insurance premiums                        | 120   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(2) – insuring a personal residence                  | 109   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(3) – business conducted incidentally at a residence | 177   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(3) – maintaining a household                        | 139   | exact     |

| VERDICT | CITATION                                                                             | CHARS | HOW / WHY |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|-----------|
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(3) – part of the house used as the place of business               | 207   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(4) – losses on property held for personal purposes                 | 276   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(5) – commuting                                                     | 137   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(5) – local lodging                                                 | 201   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(5) – meals not incurred away from home                             | 155   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(5) – travelling away from home                                     | 510   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(8) – a reservist's uniforms                                        | 335   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(8) – the sword and the uniform                                     | 121   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(8) – the test for a serviceman's equipment                         | 307   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(9) – education                                                     | 201   | exact     |
| TIED    | 26 CFR 1.262-1(c) – where a personal item is deductible anyway                       | 630   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Actual Expenses" – rent                                        | 238   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Actual Expenses" – utilities and services                      | 348   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Exceptions to Exclusive Use" – storage of inventory, the tests | 562   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Exceptions to Exclusive Use" – the basement                    | 367   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Exclusive Use" – the den the family also uses                  | 281   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Exclusive Use" – the test                                      | 399   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Principal Place of Business" – when a home office qualifies    | 343   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Qualifying for a Deduction" – the six ways to qualify          | 642   | spacing   |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Regular Use" – the test                                        | 272   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Separate Structure" – the greenhouse                           | 297   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Separate Structure" – the rule                                 | 293   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Trade or Business Use" – the taxpayer's own investments        | 362   | exact     |
| TIED    | IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Trade or Business Use" – the test                              | 253   | exact     |

## The sources, and that they can disagree with us

- **S1** — Treasury Regulation § 1.262-1 — Personal, living, and family expenses  
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-01-01/title-26.xml?section=1.262-1>
- **S2** — Treasury Regulation § 1.162-1 — Business expenses  
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-01-01/title-26.xml?section=1.162-1>
- **S3** — IRS Publication 587 (2025) — Business Use of Your Home  
<https://www.irs.gov/publications/p587>

Not one of these is ours. None is a cache, a fixture or a second copy of our own record — which is the test the tie-out skill puts first: **could this disagree with me?** Each one can, and

two of them did.

---

## How to run this yourself

Every step below has the real values already in it. Nothing here needs me.

### 1 · RE-RUN THE WHOLE CHECK

```
cd desk && python -B tools/tieout.py
```

It fetches every source live and writes `tie-outs/findings.json`. Expect it to take a few minutes: it pauses between requests rather than hammering the publishers.

### 2 · REBUILD THESE DOCUMENTS FROM THAT RUN

```
cd desk && python -B tools/tieout_exhibit.py
```

### 3 · CHECK ONE LINE BY HAND, WITHOUT EITHER SCRIPT

Take any row in the roster, fetch its URL, and look for the text yourself:

```
curl -sS --compressed "https://www.irs.gov/publications/p587" | shasum -a 256
```

If that hash matches the one printed with the exemplar above, you are reading the same bytes this document read. Then search the document for the passage — the desk prints it under that citation in the brief:

```
cd desk && python -B -c "import sys; sys.path.insert(0, '.'); import ask, record, pathlib; \
print(ask.brief('show me', record.load(pathlib.Path('desks/personal-or-business'))))" | less
```

---

## What it found

**Two differences in 533 passages, and a defect in the record that no difference would have shown.**

- **Right text, wrong link — three passages.** The rewards desk stores § 6041, § 6041A, § 6050W and § 6071 under one source whose recorded URL is the House's granule for **§ 6041 only**. A reader following that link finds the first and not the other three; the "6041A" and "6050W" they see on that page are § 6041's own cross-references. All three bodies are **verbatim correct** on their own granules, so nothing served was wrong and no test could have caught it — the numbers were right and the citation pointed somewhere that does not carry them. **Only following the link finds this.** The checker now resolves each statute citation to its own granule; the record's source URL is still under-covering and is a fix for the desk.
- **A partial quotation that does not say it is one.** Publication 583's sentence has two branches and the cash desk stores the second without marking the omission. The split is right — the branches have opposite answers, which is the defect #264 found — but an answerer reading the passage cannot tell a branch was removed.
- **A publisher's interface text inside a quotation.** `irs.gov` appends the word **PDF** to links that point at PDFs, and it sits mid-sentence on the tangible-property page. Ours

drops it, which reads correctly and is not what the page literally shows.

**And what it did not find is the point of running it.** 531 of 533 passages are, character for character, what the publisher publishes today. That was an assumption this morning and it is a measurement now.

---

## What I got wrong

**The first run reported 88 differences and 34 of them were mine.** The extractor replaced every markup tag with a space, so eCFR's `<I>election</I>—(1)` came back as `election - (1)` and `601.601(d)(2)(ii)(<I>b</I>)` as `( b )`. A checker that invents differences is worse than no checker, because somebody goes and "fixes" the record to match it. Inline tags now close up and only block tags become a space.

**Then it reported 18, and 16 of those were mine too.** pypdf reads a kerned two-column IRS page as `Y ou` and hyphenates `infor-mation` across a line break, and `irs.gov` puts block markup inside a sentence. Those are rendering artefacts of the extractor, not differences in what was published — so the comparison now runs twice, and the exhibit says which pass carried each line rather than quietly folding them together.

**I could not capture the sources as photographs, and the skill asks for photographs.**

This machine's browser cannot reach the publishers even when pointed at the egress proxy — `ERR_CONNECTION_RESET` — while the HTTP client reaches them fine. Attempted, failed, recorded. What is here instead is the document itself: its SHA-256, its length, the moment it was fetched and the publisher's own words quoted around each match. For text that is the stronger evidence, because a reader can recompute the hash and a screenshot cannot be re-verified at all.

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## What this does not prove

- **It proves the words, not the reading.** That § 1.263(a)-1(f)(1)(ii)(D) says \$500 is now established. Whether \$500 is the number that governs a client is a question about Notice 2015-82 and about the firm's election, and no fetch settles it.
- **It proves containment, not completeness.** The check asks whether our passage occurs in the publisher's document. It does not ask whether we stored the *whole* of what that citation covers — a passage could be a true fragment of a paragraph whose second half changes its meaning. Publication 583 above is exactly that failure caught by accident, not by design.
- **The whitespace-ignoring pass can hide a genuinely missing space.** 13 lines tied only on that pass. Each is named in the roster as `spacing` so nobody has to take it on trust.
- **The regulations were fetched as of 2026-01-01, not today.** eCFR's versioner refuses a future date and this is the last date known good on it. A regulation amended between that date and now would not show here.
- **One reading, not two.** The skill asks for a second rendering where one exists — the XML and the rendered page, the PDF and the HTML. Only one rendering per source was read. A digit or a word wrong in *both* our copy and the one rendering we read would pass.

- **Nothing here touches whether a desk answers well.** This is about the authority it is given. A desk with a perfect corpus can still reason badly from it, and that is what the scoreboard is for.